

THE ART OF BEING RIGHT

The Art of Being Right

One hundred and forty-four ways an
argument
is won unfairly, and what to say back.

MURTAZA RAZA

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CONTENTS

How to Use This Book	1
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PART I · MOVING THE GROUND

1	Changing the Subject	7
2	Rigging the Terms	15
3	The Straw Man and His Family	23

PART II · GOING AFTER THE PERSON

4	Playing the Man	35
5	Borrowed Authority	43
6	Purity Tests	51

PART III · ABUSING THE EVIDENCE

7	Numbers That Lie	61
8	Weaponising Doubt	69
9	False Choices	77

PART IV · PLAYING THE ROOM

10	Emotional Leverage	87
11	Running Out the Clock	97
12	When You Are the One Doing It	105

END MATTER

	A Note on Sources	113
	Index of Moves	117

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to Use This Book

This is a book of three hundred and fifteen quotations, each with a short explanation and one concrete suggestion for using it. That's the whole design. It is not a collection of inspiring lines to be admired and then forgotten by Thursday.

Quotation books fail in the same way every time. They present a beautiful sentence, attribute it to somebody impressive, and leave. You read forty in a sitting, feel briefly elevated, and retain nothing, because a sentence on its own has nowhere to attach itself. What makes an old line useful is not its elegance. It is knowing when to reach for it: which moment, which conversation, which three in the morning.

So every entry here has two parts after the quotation. The first says what the idea is, in plain English, assuming you have no interest in the person who said it or the century they said it in. The second gives you somewhere to put it. Not "be more patient" but a situation you will recognise, probably from this week.

How to read it. Not cover to cover. Twenty-one chapters of advice taken in order produces the sensation of having been lectured at for four hours, and none of it sticks. The book is arranged by problem. Go to the chapter matching whatever is bothering you

now and read three or four entries. Somebody has behaved appallingly towards you: chapter ten. You cannot make yourself start the thing: chapter fourteen. You said something stupid in a meeting on Tuesday and have been replaying it ever since: chapter twelve. You cannot stop measuring yourself against somebody: chapter six.

Dipping is not a lesser way to read this. It's the design.

On the disagreements. The entries contradict each other, sometimes within a page. One tells you to persist, another tells you to stop. One says speak up, another says leave it unsaid. This is deliberate. Real advice conflicts, because real situations differ, and any book of guidance that never disagrees with itself has been simplified into uselessness. Part of what you are being handed is the job of deciding which one applies today.

On the exits. Near the end of most chapters sits an entry that gives you permission to stop: to leave the grievance unforgiven, to stay angry about ageing, to skip the difficult conversation, to put the book down and go and live instead. They are there because advice without a limit turns into pressure, and pressure is the last thing anybody needs when they are already struggling.

On the sources. They run from Marcus Aurelius to English proverbs to a nursery rhyme about an owl, and there is no hierarchy of respectability here. A proverb that survived four hundred years of ordinary people repeating it has been tested harder than most philosophy. Where a line is disputed, or has drifted from its original wording, it is marked "attributed to" or "after", and there is a note at the back about why so

many famous quotations belong to nobody in particular.

One caution. Nothing here substitutes for medical help, legal advice, or a person who knows your actual situation. Old lines are good at perspective and unqualified to diagnose anything. If the worry will not stop, if the low period has run for months, if you are frightened of what you might do, put this down and speak to a doctor. That is not a failure to apply the wisdom. It is the wisest response available, and no proverb covers it.

Otherwise: start wherever your week hurts.

I

MOVING THE GROUND



Changing the Subject

You made a point. It was a good one, and you can tell it was good because nobody addressed it. What came back was adjacent: a related grievance, a wider principle, a question about your tone. Ten minutes later you are defending something you never said, and the original point is lying in the road behind you where it was dropped.

This is the commonest move in the book and the hardest to catch in real time, because each individual swerve is small. Nobody announces that they are leaving the subject. They arrive somewhere else by a series of reasonable-looking steps, and by the time you notice, going back looks pedantic.

That last part is the engine of the whole family. The cost of returning to the point is social, and it is paid by you. You are the one who has to say hang on, we were talking about something else, and in front of an audience that makes you the difficult one while the person who moved the ground looks relaxed and expansive.

Which is why the counter to nearly all of it is the same, and why it feels rude the first few times you do it: name the swerve, out loud, without heat, and put the original question back on the table. Not as an accusation. As bookkeeping.

The moves below are sorted roughly by how respectable they look. The first few are recognisable as evasion by anybody watching. The last few are indistinguishable from good faith, which is what makes them worth knowing.

001

“Fine, but what about what your lot did in 2019?”

Whataboutery

WHY IT WORKS

It is not a defence and it is not meant to be. It is a change of subject that feels like a rebuttal, because it puts you on the back foot morally. You now have two choices, and both lose: defend 2019, or refuse and look like you are dodging.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Take the third option. “That might well be true. It doesn’t make this true or false either way, so let’s do that one after.” You have conceded nothing, refused nothing, and put the swerve on a shelf where it can be collected later. It almost never is.

002

“I think you’re missing the bigger picture here.”

The Zoom Out

WHY IT WORKS

Any specific claim can be made to look small by standing further back. The move trades a checkable statement for

an unfalsifiable one, and it flatters the person making it as the one with perspective while you fuss over particulars.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Agree and hold. “Probably. The bigger picture still has to be made of true things, and this one is the bit I’m asking about.” The bigger picture is not a place where specific facts stop mattering, and saying so out loud makes the move visible to everyone listening.

003

“The real question is whether we should be doing this at all.”

Substituting the Question

WHY IT WORKS

It sounds like depth. It reframes your question as superficial and replaces it with one the speaker would rather answer, and because the new question is larger, arguing to keep the old one looks small-minded.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“That’s a real question and I’d like to get to it. This one has an answer we can reach today, so can we finish it first?” Sequencing beats refusing. You are not saying their question is bad, only that it is next.

004

“Look, honestly, I think we’re saying the same thing.”

The False Merge

WHY IT WORKS

It ends the disagreement by declaring it over, and it does so generously, which makes contradicting it feel churlish. If you accept, the difference between your positions quietly becomes yours to have imagined.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“We might be. Let me check: do you think X?” Name the specific claim you believe you differ on. Either they agree and the merge was real, or they do not and the disagreement is back on the table with its outline sharper than before.

005

“Let’s not get bogged down in the details.”

Dismissing the Specific

WHY IT WORKS

Details are where claims are checkable, so the move removes the ground on which the speaker can lose. It also borrows the language of leadership. Big people see the shape of things; small people count.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Happy not to, but this one is load-bearing.” Then say what it holds up. A detail that changes the conclusion is not a detail, and once you have shown which conclusion

depends on it, refusing to discuss it stops looking like decisiveness.

006

“That’s a whole other conversation.”

Deferring Forever

WHY IT WORKS

It sounds like discipline. Perfectly reasonable in a meeting with an agenda, and the trick is that the other conversation is never scheduled. The point is not postponed; it is disposed of politely.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Take the deferral literally. “Agreed. When?” A date makes the difference between managing an agenda and burying a topic, and the answer tells you which one you are in without either of you having to say so.

007

“Anyway, as I was saying before, the thing about the budget is...”

Talking Over the Answer

WHY IT WORKS

It does not engage the answer at all. It behaves as though the answer did not happen, and because interrupting to point that out costs you the room’s sympathy, the non-response stands.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Wait for the pause, then flatly: “Before the budget, I answered your question about the timeline. Do you want

to respond to that, or shall we move on?" The offer to move on is what makes it survivable. It gives them an exit while making the skip a matter of record.

008

"You've clearly thought about this a great deal."

The Compliment Exit

WHY IT WORKS

Praise closes a conversation more effectively than disagreement. It signals warmth, ends the exchange, and concedes nothing, and anyone who pushes past a compliment looks like they cannot take yes for an answer.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Take the warmth and keep going. "Thank you. So where do you land on it?" Pleasant, unmoved, and it converts the compliment back into a question, which was what you asked for.

009

"Well, it's more complicated than that."

Complexity as a Shield

WHY IT WORKS

It is almost always true, which is what makes it so useful. Everything is more complicated than any summary of it. Stated without a follow-up, it functions as a refusal dressed as sophistication.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

"It usually is. Which part have I got wrong?" Complexity that cannot name the specific simplification is not complexity, it is a stop sign. Asking makes them either supply the correction, which is useful, or reveal there wasn't one.

010

"I mean, at the end of the day, who's to say what's true?"

The Fog Machine

WHY IT WORKS

By making everything uncertain, it makes your specific claim no better than theirs. It is the argumentative equivalent of turning off the lights: nobody can see anything, which suits whoever was losing.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Bring it down to something small and checkable. "Was the report delivered on the fourteenth?" Universal doubt evaporates on contact with a date, an invoice or a document, and it becomes obvious that the fog was tactical.

011

"I think we're just going to have to agree to disagree."

The Premature Truce

WHY IT WORKS

It sounds like maturity and it is often exactly right. The abuse is in the timing: deployed the moment a position is

in trouble, it converts a losing argument into a respectable draw, and refusing it makes you the aggressor.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Accept it and put down a marker. “Fine by me. For the record, the bit I don’t think has been answered is X.” You have granted the truce, which costs you nothing, while declining to let the unanswered thing be filed as answered.

012

“Sorry, what were we even talking about?”

Losing the Thread on Purpose

WHY IT WORKS

After enough diversions, genuine confusion is indistinguishable from manufactured confusion, and the person who restates the question does the work while sounding obsessive for having tracked it.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Have it written down. This is the entire counter, and it is why people who argue for a living take notes. “You asked whether the figures were signed off. I said no. You asked who by.” Reading it back is unanswerable, and the fact that you can do it once changes how the next hour goes.

Rigging the Terms

Whoever settles what the words mean has settled the argument, and they have done it before anybody noticed a decision was being made. This is why the opening minutes of a disagreement matter more than the next hour. A term accepted early is a term you are stuck with, and by the time its shape becomes inconvenient it has hardened into common ground.

The moves in this chapter all work on the same seam. Language is loose. Almost every word worth arguing about has a range rather than a point, and inside that range there is room to move without ever saying anything false. A cut becomes a realignment. A loss becomes a rounding error. A promise becomes an aspiration, and nothing has been retracted, because nothing was ever nailed down.

What makes these hard to counter is that the correction sounds petty. Objecting to a word, when everybody can see roughly what was meant, casts you as the person who cares more about vocabulary than about the thing itself. That impression is exactly what the move is buying.

So the counter is almost always to convert the word into something with edges. Not to argue about the

definition, which is a swamp, but to ask what would be true in the world if the word applied, and what would be true if it did not. A term that cannot answer that question was doing no work in the first place, and once that is visible, the move stops paying.

One warning before the list. Precision is not automatically virtuous. Some people demand definitions to avoid conclusions, and that move is in here too, near the end.

013

“Well, it rather depends what you mean by fair.”

Definitional Retreat

WHY IT WORKS

It answers a claim with a question, and the question is unanswerable in the time available. Any definition you offer can be met with an edge case, so you spend the argument defending a dictionary instead of a position.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Refuse the abstraction and supply an instance. “I mean that Ali was paid forty percent less for the same job. Is that fair?” A concrete case cannot be dissolved into definitional fog, and if they still will not answer, everybody watching now knows why.

014

“That isn’t really capitalism, though. Real capitalism has never been tried.”

No True Scotsman

WHY IT WORKS

It saves the idea by expelling every example of it, and it does so with no visible cost, because the speaker never has to admit anything failed. The category simply loses members until only successes remain.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask what would count. “What would a real one look like, and has it ever existed anywhere?” If nothing in history qualifies, the claim has quietly become unfalsifiable, and that is worth saying plainly rather than arguing about Sweden.

015

“I’d call that a rounding error rather than a loss.”

Renaming the Thing

WHY IT WORKS

The new word carries a different emotional weight while pointing at the same facts, and because it is not technically false, correcting it looks like quibbling. Repeated a few times, the new name sticks and the thing feels smaller.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Put the number back in. “It’s eighty thousand pounds. Whatever we call it, is eighty thousand acceptable?”

Names bend. Figures do not, and returning to the figure makes the renaming look like what it was.

016

“It’s not a cut. It’s a realignment of resources.”

The Euphemism

WHY IT WORKS

Euphemism does not deceive anybody, which is not its job. Its job is to make objecting feel hysterical. Complaining about a realignment sounds unhinged in a way that complaining about a cut does not.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask the mechanical question. “Will there be less money in that budget next year than this year?” A yes converts the euphemism back into the thing, without you ever having accused anyone of spin.

017

“So you accept the project was a failure.”

Upgrading Your Concession

WHY IT WORKS

You conceded something small and it comes back enlarged. Because you did concede, denying the enlarged version looks like backtracking, and you spend the next five minutes defending a position you never held.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Restate your own concession precisely and immediately. “I said the launch date slipped. That’s what I accept.” Do

it the moment it happens. Left for even a minute, the upgraded version becomes the one in everybody's memory.

018

"You're using disinterested wrong. It means impartial."

Policing the Word, Not the Point

WHY IT WORKS

The correction is often right, which is what gives it force. It also transfers authority: the person who knows the word looks like the person who knows the subject, and your argument is now on probation for a fault that has nothing to do with it.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Concede instantly and move. "Fair enough, uninterested. So does the objection stand?" The concession costs nothing and denies them the thing they were buying, which was the pause.

019

"By any reasonable definition, this is a success."

Smuggling the Conclusion In

WHY IT WORKS

The conclusion is inside the definition, so agreeing to the definition is agreeing to the conclusion, and the word *reasonable* makes disagreement sound unreasonable before you have opened your mouth.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Unpick it before answering. “Let’s separate those. What’s the definition, and then separately, does this meet it?” Splitting the two makes the smuggling visible, and it turns out that the definition was built around this case.

020

“Oh come on, everyone knows what I meant.”

Refusing to Be Pinned

WHY IT WORKS

It converts a request for precision into an accusation of bad faith, and it works especially well in front of an audience, who do know roughly what was meant and now think you are playing games.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Give them the easiest possible route to precision. “I think you meant X. Is that right?” Offering the interpretation rather than demanding one removes the excuse, and if X is wrong they now have to say what is right.

021

“That’s just semantics.”

Dismissing Definition When It Suits

WHY IT WORKS

Deployed by whoever benefits from the looser word, right after they have themselves insisted on a precise one. It sounds like impatience with pedantry and functions as a refusal to be specific.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“It’s semantics when the meaning doesn’t change the answer. Here it does, because X.” Then show the two readings and the two different conclusions. That is the whole distinction, and stating it once tends to end this particular move for the rest of the conversation.

022

“Before we go further, we should define our terms.”

The Definitional Filibuster

WHY IT WORKS

It is unimpeachable in principle, and in practice it can consume every minute available. Nobody can object to defining terms, so the argument never reaches the part where somebody might lose it.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Timebox it out loud. “Agreed, five minutes, then we take the question as it stands.” Naming a limit converts an infinite process into a finite one and makes any further stalling visible as stalling.

023

“I never said that.”

The Retroactive Edit

WHY IT WORKS

Memory is weak and nobody has a transcript. In most rooms the confident denial beats the accurate recollection, and pursuing it makes you look like you are keeping score.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Do keep score, and quote rather than characterise. “You said the figures were signed off. I wrote it down at the time.” Then move on immediately, without demanding an admission. The record is the point; the apology is not worth the ten minutes.

024

“If you’re going to be pedantic about it.”

Making Precision a Character Flaw

WHY IT WORKS

It reframes accuracy as a personality defect. Once the room accepts that you are the pedant, every subsequent correction you make is discounted before it is heard, however material it turns out to be.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Own it lightly and carry on. “I am, about this one, because the answer changes depending on it.” Cheerful ownership defuses the label. Defending yourself against it confirms it.

The Straw Man and His Family

The straw man is the most famous move in this book and the least well understood. Everybody can name it. Almost nobody catches it happening to them in the moment, because a good one does not misrepresent you wildly. It misrepresents you slightly, in a direction that is easier to attack, and it does so while sounding like a fair summary offered in good faith.

The tell is that the restatement always makes your position more extreme, never less. Nobody has ever accidentally paraphrased an opponent into a more reasonable position than the one they held. That asymmetry is the whole family resemblance, and once you have noticed it you cannot stop seeing it.

There is a second thing worth knowing, which is that the person doing it is often sincere. Arguments are exhausting and the mind economises by simplifying the other side into something manageable. Half the straw men you will meet are not tactics; they are laziness that happens to be self-serving. This matters for the counter, because treating a sincere simplification as a deliberate smear turns a solvable exchange into a fight.

So the counter is nearly always the same shape, and it is boring on purpose: restate your own position, in one sentence, without complaint about the misrepresentation. Not that isn't what I said, which invites a row about what you said. Just the sentence, again, cleanly. Then ask the question again.

Do it twice and most people correct course. Do it three times and you have learned something about who you are talking to.

025

“So what you’re saying is we should just do nothing.”

The Straw Man

WHY IT WORKS

The exaggerated version is easy to refute, so refuting it produces the feeling of a win in the room. It also puts you on defence, which means you have stopped advancing your own case for as long as the correction takes.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Give the sentence, not the objection. “What I’m saying is we should do the first two and wait on the third.” No indignation, no accusation. The clean restatement is faster than the argument about whether they misrepresented you, and it works on sincere and cynical versions alike.

026

“So basically you don’t care about the people affected.”

The Motive Upgrade

WHY IT WORKS

It converts a disagreement about policy into a claim about your character, and character is much harder to defend than a position. Any defence sounds like protesting too much, and refusing to defend sounds like an admission.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Decline the frame flatly, once. “I care about them and I think this makes it worse for them. That’s the disagreement.” Then return to the substance without waiting. Litigating your own decency is a trap with no exit; declining it in one sentence is the only version that works.

027

“By that logic we’d have to ban ladders.”

The Reductio That Isn’t

WHY IT WORKS

A real reduction to absurdity shows that your principle produces a conclusion you would reject. The fake version applies your principle to a case it never covered, and it lands because the audience rarely checks whether the extension was legitimate.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Name the missing condition. “My argument had a threshold in it. Ladders don’t cross it.” If the principle

does entail the absurd case, they have found a real hole and you should say so; if it does not, showing the join ends the move immediately.

028

“What you’re really arguing for is a two-tier system.”

Telling You What You Think

WHY IT WORKS

The word **really** claims access to your actual position underneath your stated one. It is unanswerable by denial, because denying it can be presented as further evidence that you have not admitted it even to yourself.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Refuse the archaeology. “I’ll tell you what I’m arguing for. It’s X.” Say it once, without heat. You are the authority on your own claim, and asserting that calmly is more effective than proving a negative about your hidden intentions.

029

“Suppose someone said all landlords are criminals. Would you defend that?”

The Hypothetical Sock Puppet

WHY IT WORKS

An invented opponent is introduced who holds a position nobody in the room does, and you are asked to answer for them. Refuse and you look evasive; engage and you have spent your time on somebody who does not exist.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Decline the hypothetical and offer the real one. "I've no idea, nobody here said that. Ask me about what I did say." Short and unembarrassed. The invented opponent only survives while somebody agrees to debate them.

030

"Once you allow this, where does it end?"

The Slippery Slope

WHY IT WORKS

The chain always sounds plausible because each individual link is small, and refuting it requires arguing about a future nobody can check. It also carries real force, because sometimes slopes are genuinely slippery.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask for the mechanism. "What's the step from here to there, and what stops it?" A real slope can name the mechanism, and then it is a serious argument you should take seriously. A fake one names only the destination, and asking makes that gap obvious.

031

"That's exactly what they said in the 1930s."

Guilt by Historical Association

WHY IT WORKS

It attaches a repellent association to a position without claiming any actual similarity, and the association does all the work. Denying it means talking about the 1930s, which is time not spent on the question.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Test whether the analogy carries anything. “Which part of the comparison do you think holds?” Almost always the answer is the surface, and asking makes the speaker either supply a real parallel worth discussing or drop it quietly.

032

“I’m just asking questions.”

Just Asking Questions

WHY IT WORKS

It advances a claim while retaining the right to deny having made one. The question plants the implication and the disclaimer removes the responsibility, so there is nothing to rebut and everything to worry about.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Convert the question into the claim it contains. “The question implies X. Do you think X?” A yes is progress, because now there is an actual position on the table. A no should be followed by dropping the question, and if it is not, everyone can see it.

033

“A lot of people are saying the figures were manipulated.”

The Anonymous Ally

WHY IT WORKS

It borrows the weight of a crowd without naming anybody, so there is no source to check and no claim the

speaker owns. Disagreeing puts you against an unspecified many rather than against one person in the room.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask who, without sarcasm. “Which people? I’d like to read it.” If the crowd is real you get a source and learn something. If it is not, the request is enough, and it is noticeably harder to run the move a second time.

034

“Oh, so we should just trust them, should we.”

The Sarcastic Restatement

WHY IT WORKS

Sarcasm delivers a straw man while pre-emptively mocking the correction, so pointing out the misrepresentation also means being the person who cannot take a joke. Two moves in one sentence, and the second protects the first.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Answer the literal question as though it were sincere. “Not blindly, no. I’d check the audit, which is what I’m suggesting.” Treating sarcasm as a real question strips it of its cover, and it does so without ever addressing the tone, which is where the fight would be.

035

“Nobody is saying we should abolish the whole thing.”

The Pre-emptive Straw Man

WHY IT WORKS

It is aimed at a position you have not taken, and it inoculates the room against you taking anything near it. Whatever you now propose is measured against the extreme version that was raised on your behalf and disowned.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Take back the range. “Agreed, and I’m not. What I’m proposing is the narrow version, which is X.” State it early and specifically. Once the extreme is in the air, the only cure is to be conspicuously more precise than the situation seems to need.

036

“That’s a strawman.”

The Straw Man Accusation as a Move

WHY IT WORKS

The name of the fallacy has become a move in its own right. Deployed against an accurate summary, it lets somebody dodge a fair characterisation of their position by accusing you of the very thing you have not done.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Offer them the pen. “Then give me the version you’d sign.” If they produce one, you now have their position in their own words, which is what you wanted. If they will

not, the accusation was doing work their argument could not.

II

GOING AFTER THE PERSON



Playing the Man

At some point in a losing argument, the subject changes from the claim to the person making it. It rarely happens as an insult. Insults are easy to see and easy to answer. It happens as a small observation about you, offered almost sympathetically, which has the effect of making everything you go on to say worth slightly less.

The mechanism is discounting. Nobody needs to prove you wrong if they can establish that you are the sort of person who would say this: too invested, too emotional, too junior, too partisan, too personally involved. Once the discount is applied, your evidence still exists but it has been marked down, and the room applies the markdown without deciding to.

The trap in responding is that defending yourself concedes the frame. Every minute spent establishing that you are not emotional is a minute in which the topic is your emotional state, which is exactly where the move wanted the conversation to be. Protesting the discount applies it.

So nearly every counter in this chapter has the same two beats. Grant the observation, briefly and without drama, and then decline its relevance in the same breath. Yes, I am invested. Here is the evidence. The

grant removes the fight over the fact, and the pivot puts the claim back in the room where it can be checked.

One of these is not like the others, and it is the last. Sometimes the person is disqualified, and knowing when the move is legitimate is what stops you from becoming its practitioner.

037

“Well, you would say that, wouldn’t you.”

The Motive Sneer

WHY IT WORKS

It explains your position instead of engaging it. Once your view has a cause, it no longer needs a refutation, and the cause offered is always something self-interested rather than something reasoned.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Grant and pivot in one sentence. “I would, and it’s also true. Here’s the figure.” Denying the motive is a losing game because motives are invisible. Accepting it costs you nothing as long as the evidence follows immediately.

038

“You’re getting very emotional about this.”

Tone Policing

WHY IT WORKS

It moves the subject from the argument to your delivery of it, and it is self-confirming: any objection to being called emotional can be presented as emotion. It also im-

plies a standard of calm that the speaker has appointed themselves to judge.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Do not adjust and do not deny. "I care about it, yes. Does that change the numbers?" Refusing both the denial and the correction leaves them holding a comment about your voice while everybody waits for an answer about the thing.

039

"With the greatest respect, that's simply not how it works."

The Politeness Wrapper

WHY IT WORKS

The wrapper buys social permission for the contents. Everybody hears the courtesy and files the dismissal as reasonable, and objecting to the substance now means objecting to somebody being polite to you.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Take the wrapper off and answer the middle. "How does it work, then?" No comment on the tone at all. The demand for the actual claim is what the courtesy was substituting for.

040

“Are you actually qualified to have a view on this?”

The Credential Challenge

WHY IT WORKS

It shifts the burden from the claim to the claimant, and the claimant almost never has quite the right credential, because nobody does. It is also socially costly to answer, since listing your qualifications makes you look defensive.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Send it back to the argument. “Probably not. Which part of what I said is wrong?” Arguments do not have credentials; they have premises and a conclusion. Saying so once is enough, and it is unanswerable without engaging.

041

“You’ve obviously got skin in the game here.”

Interest as Refutation

WHY IT WORKS

Interest is real and worth knowing about, which is what makes this so effective as a smear. It is also universal: everybody has an interest in something, so the move can be run on anyone at any time.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Declare it first and keep going. “I do, I’ve said so, and the audit says the same thing.” Disclosed interest is much weaker than exposed interest, which is why saying it before they do removes most of the charge.

042

“That’s not what you said last year.”

The Consistency Trap

WHY IT WORKS

It substitutes a claim about your record for a claim about the world, and it makes changing your mind look like a defect rather than a response to evidence. Both positions cannot be right, so you must have been wrong once, and doubt attaches to the current one.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Own the change and give the reason. “It isn’t. The figures came in and I changed my mind.” Then stop. A stated reason converts the inconsistency from a character flaw into the ordinary thing it is, and nobody can attack you for updating without sounding foolish.

043

“Calm down.”

The Calm-Down

WHY IT WORKS

It cannot be answered without appearing to prove the point, and it costs nothing to say. It also grants the speaker the role of the composed adult, which is worth more in most rooms than any argument.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Do not defend your composure. “I’m calm. The question is still open.” Say it in exactly the register you were already using. Matching your tone to your words is more

convincing than any protest, and it returns the floor to the topic in six words.

044

“I’m honestly a bit surprised at you.”

Disappointment as Argument

WHY IT WORKS

It applies social pressure without making any claim that can be tested. Disappointment implies a standard you have fallen below, and you are invited to work out what it was and climb back up, which takes the rest of the conversation.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask for the content. “Surprised at what, specifically?” Disappointment that has to name its object turns out to be disagreement, and once it is named as disagreement it can be argued with.

045

“That’s such a typical response from someone in your position.”

Category Assignment

WHY IT WORKS

It answers you as a representative rather than as a person, so anything you say is evidence of the category rather than evidence about the world. It is also the fastest way to make an audience stop listening to specifics.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Decline membership without arguing about the category. "I can only tell you what I think. Which bit of it is wrong?" Do not defend the group; that is a separate and much longer argument, and taking it up is how the move wins its time.

046

"You clearly haven't read the report."

Assumed Ignorance

WHY IT WORKS

If true it is devastating, and if false it costs the speaker nothing to have guessed. Either way you now have to prove you have read something, which is both tedious and impossible to do convincingly in a sentence.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Quote it. "Page eleven says the opposite of what you just described." One specific reference does more than any protestation, and it reverses the assumption permanently for the rest of the discussion.

047

"I'm not attacking you personally, obviously."

Denying the Attack While Making It

WHY IT WORKS

The disclaimer functions as a shield for whatever follows, and it pre-empts your objection by having already denied the thing. If you then say it felt personal, you are contra-

dicting a stated intention, which sounds like an accusation of lying.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ignore the frame and answer the content. Responding to the disclaimer is the trap; there is nothing there to engage. If the content was itself an attack with no argument in it, the fair response is “there’s no claim in that I can answer,” said mildly, once.

048

“I’ve known Tom for twenty years and he’d never do that.”

Character Reference as Evidence

WHY IT WORKS

It substitutes a general impression for particular facts, and it is emotionally powerful because it is often sincere. Contradicting it means appearing to call a decent person’s judgement of their friend into question.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Separate the two things gently. “I believe you about who he is. The question is what happened on the fourteenth.” Character is evidence, weakly, about propensity. It is not evidence about a specific event, and the distinction can be made without any suggestion that anybody is lying.

Borrowed Authority

Nobody has time to verify anything, and everybody knows it. That is the gap these moves live in. An argument that would take an hour to establish can be won in four seconds by attaching it to something the room already trusts: a study, a discipline, a famous name, thirty years of experience, common sense.

None of this is illegitimate in itself. Deference to expertise is not a fallacy; it is how anyone functions in a world too large to check personally. You trust the pharmacist. The abuse is not in citing authority, it is in citing an authority that has not said the thing, or that has no standing on the question, or that cannot be located at all.

Which gives the whole chapter a single counter, applied with different manners depending on the room: ask for the reference. Not aggressively, and not as a challenge to the person's honesty. As interest. Where can I read that? is a sentence that costs nothing to say, is impossible to object to, and is fatal to about eighty percent of the moves below.

The reason it works is that the borrowed authority is real but vague, and vagueness cannot survive a request for specifics. Either you get a source, in which

case you have learned something and the conversation improves, or you do not, and everybody has watched you not get one.

Ask once, mildly, and then let the silence do the work. Asking twice turns it into a fight about your scepticism.

049

“Studies show that it actually increases costs.”

The Unnamed Study

WHY IT WORKS

The word **studies**, plural and anonymous, borrows the entire authority of research without accepting any of its accountability. There is nothing to check, and doubting it sounds like doubting science.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Which one? I’d genuinely like to read it.” The word **genuinely** matters, because it removes the accusation. Most of the time no study is produced, and the claim deflates without you ever having called anyone a liar.

050

“Every expert in the field agrees.”

The Consensus Claim

WHY IT WORKS

It makes disagreement into eccentricity. Whatever you say next is positioned against the whole profession, and the audience has no way to check whether the consensus exists or whether it covers this exact question.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Narrow it to the claim. “Agrees on what precisely? There’s usually consensus on some parts and not others.” Real consensus survives specificity easily. Invented consensus is always broader than any real one, and asking exposes the width.

051

“As Einstein said, insanity is doing the same thing and expecting different results.”

The Misattributed Quote

WHY IT WORKS

The name does the persuading, not the sentence. Four names attract orphaned quotations more than any others: Einstein, Twain, Churchill and the Buddha. A neat line under any of them deserves suspicion, and this particular one is not Einstein’s at all.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Leave the attribution alone unless it matters, and go at the claim. “Whoever said it, is it true here? We’ve changed three things since last time.” Correcting the source scores a point and loses the thread; testing the sentence keeps the argument where you want it.

052

“I’ve been doing this for thirty years.”

Experience as Trump Card

WHY IT WORKS

Experience is valuable and impossible to acquire quickly, so it cannot be matched in the room. It also converts dis-

agreement into disrespect, which most people will avoid at some cost to their argument.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask experience to do what only experience can. “Then you’ll have seen this before. What happened those times?” Thirty years used as a claim is an assertion of rank; thirty years used as data is useful, and the question invites the second.

053

“Do your own research.”

Outsourcing the Burden

WHY IT WORKS

It shifts the entire cost of establishing a claim onto the person who doubts it, while allowing the claim to stand in the meantime. It also implies your ignorance is the reason for the disagreement.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Decline the transfer, once, pleasantly. “You made the claim, so you’ll have the source to hand. Where is it?” Whoever asserts, supports. That rule is not pedantry; it is the only thing that makes discussion possible at all.

054

“It’s basic economics, honestly.”

The Discipline Invocation

WHY IT WORKS

Naming a field implies that the answer is settled within it and that you would know this if you were educated. It

works especially well with economics, physics and law, which most people have encountered enough to feel unqualified about.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask which part. “Which bit of it? I want to look it up.” Genuine textbook results are easy to name. When the invocation is a bluff, the specific never arrives, and the field goes back to being irrelevant to the question.

055

“Common sense tells you that won’t work.”

Common Sense as Authority

WHY IT WORKS

It presents a contested claim as something obvious to any reasonable person, which makes disagreement a sign of either foolishness or ideology. It also requires no evidence at all, which is its great efficiency.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Common sense also said heavier things fall faster. What’s the evidence here?” One counterexample is enough. The point is not that common sense is worthless, only that it is a hypothesis rather than a verdict.

056

“Even the auditors agree with me on this.”

The Endorsement Grab

WHY IT WORKS

It recruits a third party who is not in the room to defend a position they may not hold, and because checking

would be awkward, the endorsement usually stands unexamined for the length of the conversation.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask what they agreed to. “Agreed on which finding? I read the report differently.” Endorsements shrink under specificity. Often it turns out the third party agreed with something adjacent, which is worth knowing and worth saying out loud.

057

“That’s been thoroughly debunked.”

The Debunk Claim

WHY IT WORKS

It asserts that the argument is not merely wrong but already dealt with, so engaging with it would be a waste of everyone’s time. It borrows the authority of a process that may never have happened.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“By whom, and where? I’d like to see it.” Same request as always. A real debunking is easy to point at and settles the matter properly, which is a good outcome. A claimed one dissolves.

058

“It’s peer reviewed, actually.”

The Credential of the Source

WHY IT WORKS

It answers a question about the content with a fact about the container. Peer review is a filter, not a guarantee, and

treating it as a guarantee ends the conversation with the appearance of rigour.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Accept the credential and ask about the finding. “Good, so what did it actually measure?” Sample size, method, and what the paper claims as opposed to what the headline claims are all fair questions that respect the review process rather than dismissing it.

059

“My cousin works in the hospital and she says it’s nothing like that.”

The Anecdotal Insider

WHY IT WORKS

A named human being with proximity beats an abstract statistic every time. It also cannot be checked and cannot be doubted politely, since doubting it means doubting somebody’s cousin.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Give the anecdote its due and set it beside the data. “That’s one hospital, and it might well be the worst one. What does the national figure say?” Nothing here calls the cousin a liar, which is what makes it possible to say.

060

“Look, I’m not an expert, but it seems obvious to me that...”

The Humble Shield

WHY IT WORKS

The disclaimer buys immunity in advance. If the claim is challenged, the speaker has already said they are no expert, so a rebuttal looks like bullying somebody who was being modest.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Take the modesty at face value and treat the claim normally. “Nor am I. Here’s what the figures show.” The shield only works if you attack the person. Answering the claim as though it were offered seriously, which it was, leaves the disclaimer with nothing to protect.

Purity Tests

There is a kind of argument that is not really an argument. It is an examination, and the subject is you. Not what you have said, but whether you have standing to say it: whether you care enough, whether your hands are clean, whether you were there before it was easy, whether your life is consistent with your position.

These moves are the most effective in this book among people who broadly agree with each other, which is what makes them worth a chapter. They are rarely used across a real divide, because they only work if you want the tester's approval. Between allies they are devastating, and they are how good arguments get lost inside groups that would have benefited from hearing them.

They also have a quality the other chapters mostly lack: they are frequently made in complete sincerity, by people who are upset. Something matters enormously to them, you have said something that sounds insufficiently urgent about it, and the test is the shape their distress takes. Treating that as a debating trick is both unkind and ineffective.

So the counter runs on two tracks. Acknowledge the thing underneath, which is usually real, and decline

the test itself, which is not a claim and cannot be passed. The acknowledgement is what makes the refusal survivable. Without it you look cold, and looking cold is the outcome the test is best at producing.

There is one honest version in here and it is the last entry, because sometimes the person has no standing, and pretending otherwise helps nobody.

061

“If you actually cared about this you’d have said something months ago.”

The Sincerity Test

WHY IT WORKS

It makes the timing of your concern the evidence for its authenticity, and there is no timing that passes. Early is opportunism, late is bandwagoning, and now is suspicious.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Answer the question underneath rather than the charge. “I should have. I’m saying it now, and here’s what I think we do.” Agreeing you were late costs almost nothing and removes the only fuel the move had, which was your defensiveness about the date.

062

“Honestly, you’re part of the problem here.”

Complicity Assignment

WHY IT WORKS

It converts disagreement into causation. You are no longer someone with a different view; you are one of the

reasons the situation persists, which means engaging with your argument would itself be a form of collaboration.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Decline once, without indignation, and stay on the substance. "I might be. The proposal still has the flaw I described." Arguing about whether you are part of the problem is the trap, because it is unfalsifiable and it takes the rest of the evening.

063

"Where were you when we needed people?"

The Attendance Record

WHY IT WORKS

It substitutes a biography for an argument, and most biographies have gaps. It also has real moral weight behind it, because people who did the work when it was costly are owed something, and everybody in the room knows it.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Give the credit and keep the claim. "You were there and I wasn't, and I'm grateful. This part still doesn't add up." Refusing to compete on record makes the move stop, and acknowledging the debt is not a concession on the substance.

064

“That’s a very comfortable thing to say from where you’re sitting.”

Position as Disqualification

WHY IT WORKS

It attaches your argument to your circumstances, and comfort is disqualifying in a way that nothing else is. It cannot be denied, because you are indeed sitting where you are sitting.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Concede the position, contest the inference. “It is comfortable, and I might be wrong for that reason. Is the number wrong?” Where somebody stands is a reason to check their work harder. It is not a finding about the work.

065

“You can’t say that and still fly to Spain every summer.”

The Hypocrisy Catch

WHY IT WORKS

Hypocrisy is unattractive, and pointing it out feels like a substantive win. What it actually establishes is a fact about the arguer, not about the argument, but the two are hard to keep apart in the moment.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Admit it flatly and separate the questions. “I’m a hypocrite about this and the policy would still work.” Immediate admission is disarming, because the move relies on

your reluctance to concede. A hypocrite can be right, and an argument does not improve when a better person makes it.

066

“So you’re on their side now, are you.”

Forced Alignment

WHY IT WORKS

It converts a specific disagreement into a change of team, which raises the cost of the disagreement enormously. Most people will abandon a good point rather than be re-assigned.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Refuse the binary in one sentence. “I’m not on anyone’s side. I think this particular claim is wrong, for this particular reason.” The specificity is what breaks it. Sides deal in generalities, and a narrow claim is hard to conscript.

067

“This isn’t some academic debate. These are people’s lives.”

Denying the Argument’s Standing

WHY IT WORKS

It reframes analysis as indifference. If the stakes are high enough, examining the argument becomes a luxury, and the person examining it becomes someone who has failed to grasp the seriousness.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Turn the stakes around. “That’s exactly why the plan has to be right. If it doesn’t work, those are the people it fails.” High stakes are the strongest possible reason for scrutiny, not against it, and saying so makes the move backfire cleanly.

068

“Read the room.”

Social Pressure as Refutation

WHY IT WORKS

It reports a fact about the crowd and offers it as a fact about the world. It is entirely honest about being an appeal to conformity, which is somehow what makes it so difficult to answer without sounding contrarian.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Acknowledge the room and hold the point. “I know I’m the only one saying it. Is it wrong?” Being outnumbered is not evidence. Saying that calmly, without any suggestion that being outnumbered makes you right either, is the whole answer.

069

“I really shouldn’t have to explain this to you.”

The Refusal to Argue

WHY IT WORKS

It positions your question as so basic that answering it would be beneath the speaker, which converts their inab-

ility or unwillingness to explain into a comment on your ignorance.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Accept the ignorance cheerfully. "You don't have to. But I'd understand it better if you did." Taking the low status on purpose removes the sting and leaves the request standing, which is the only thing you wanted.

070

"Just do better."

The Unfalsifiable Demand

WHY IT WORKS

It sounds like a standard and contains none. There is no action that satisfies it and no way to demonstrate compliance, so it can be repeated indefinitely regardless of what you actually do.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask for the specific. "I'd like to. What would you want me to do differently?" A real complaint can answer that, and then you have something to act on. One that cannot has told you it was about position rather than behaviour.

071

"That's an interesting position for you of all people to take."

The Implication

WHY IT WORKS

It makes an accusation without stating one, so there is nothing to deny. Whatever the room imagines you are be-

ing accused of is worse and vaguer than anything the speaker would have said out loud.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Bring it into the open, without heat. “Go on, say what you mean.” Insinuation depends on not being asked to become a claim. Most of the time it will not survive the invitation, and either way the vagueness ends.

072

“Nobody serious believes that any more.”

The Fashion Argument

WHY IT WORKS

It dates your position rather than refuting it, and being out of date is a social failure rather than an intellectual one, so there is nothing to argue with. It is also sometimes true, which is the honest version of this move.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask what changed. “What came out that changed people’s minds? I’ll read it.” If there is a genuine development, you have learned something and should update. If the answer is only that the mood moved, everybody has now heard that, and mood is not evidence.

III

ABUSING THE EVIDENCE

Numbers That Lie

Almost none of the figures in this chapter are false. That is the thing worth understanding before the list. A dishonest statistic is rare, easy to catch and legally dangerous. A true statistic, chosen carefully and presented without its context, is safe, common, and far more effective.

The work is done by omission. Every number is a comparison in disguise, and the comparison is where the meaning lives. Three hundred percent of what. Two million out of how much. Nine out of ten of whom, asked by whom, out of how many who were asked and did not reply. Give a number without its denominator and it can mean whatever the room needs it to mean.

This puts an unpleasant obligation on you, which is that you have to do arithmetic in public, slowly, while somebody who has already done it watches. There is no way round that. The counters below are all versions of one question asked in different clothes: **compared to what?**

Two habits make it survivable. Ask for the base before you argue about the conclusion, because once the conclusion is on the table the base looks like a dodge. And be willing to say you cannot evaluate the figure yet, which sounds weak and is the single most defens-

ible position available when you have been handed a number you have not seen before.

073

“Complaints are up three hundred percent since the change.”

The Percentage With No Base

WHY IT WORKS

A percentage sounds like a measurement and is a ratio, and the ratio is meaningless without the starting number. Three complaints becoming twelve is three hundred percent, and so is thirty thousand becoming a hundred and twenty thousand.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Up from what to what?” Ask before responding to the implication. Four words, and about half the time the answer makes the point evaporate on the spot without you having to make any argument at all.

074

“We’ve saved two million pounds.”

The Number With No Denominator

WHY IT WORKS

Two million is large in ordinary life and can be trivial or enormous in an institution, and without the total there is no way to know which. The figure borrows its weight from the listener’s household rather than from the budget it came out of.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Out of what total, over what period?” Two million from four hundred million over five years is a rounding adjustment. The same figure from a twelve million pound budget in one year is a different story, and the phrasing is identical.

075

“Nine out of ten users said they preferred it.”

The Sample You Are Not Shown

WHY IT WORKS

The ratio is reported and the sampling is not. Ten out of eleven people who bothered to respond to an email sent to people who had already opted in is a real nine out of ten, and it tells you nothing about users.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“How many were asked, and how many answered?” Response rate is where most survey claims die. It is a neutral, technical question that nobody can take offence at, and it does more damage than any argument about methodology.

076

“Since the policy came in, waiting times have fallen.”

After, Therefore Because

WHY IT WORKS

Two things happened in an order and the order implies the cause. It is the way human beings naturally read events, so it needs no argument to be persuasive and considerable argument to dislodge.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask what else moved. “What were waiting times doing before the policy, and what happened in comparable places without it?” A trend that was already falling, or one that fell everywhere, answers the question and does so with the speaker’s own data.

077

“The average salary in the team is sixty-eight thousand.”

The Mean Hiding the Spread

WHY IT WORKS

The mean is dragged by extremes, so one very large number at the top can lift the average well above what almost everybody actually earns. The word **average** implies typical, and here it means nothing of the sort.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“What’s the median?” One word. The gap between mean and median is the whole story, and asking for it is so obvi-

ously reasonable that refusing looks worse than any answer.

078

“The result was statistically significant.”

Significance Mistaken for Size

WHY IT WORKS

The technical meaning is that an effect is unlikely to be zero. The everyday meaning is that it matters. The two get conflated, and a real but tiny effect gets discussed as though it were a large one.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Significant, but how big is the effect?” A drug that reliably lowers something by half a percent is significant and useless. Separating the two questions is not scepticism about the study; it is reading it correctly.

079

“That difference is within the margin of error.”

Margin of Error as a Dismissal

WHY IT WORKS

It sounds like rigour and is often deployed selectively, to dismiss unwelcome results while accepting equally uncertain ones that point the other way. Most listeners will not track the asymmetry.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Apply it evenly. “Then the one you cited earlier is too, isn’t it?” Consistency is the counter to selective rigour,

and pointing at the earlier figure does it in one sentence without any accusation.

080

“Just look at the graph, the line is nearly vertical.”

The Truncated Axis

WHY IT WORKS

A vertical axis starting at ninety-four rather than zero turns a two percent change into a cliff. Nothing is falsified. The eye reads slope as magnitude and the axis label goes unread.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“What does the y-axis start at?” Then read the two end values aloud. Saying the actual numbers out loud is what undoes the picture, because the picture was doing work the numbers cannot support.

081

“Compared to 2020, we’re doing enormously better.”

The Chosen Baseline

WHY IT WORKS

Every series has a best year and a worst year to be compared against, and the choice is made silently. 2020 is the great modern example, because almost any measure improves when the comparison is the year the world stopped.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“What about against 2019, and against the ten-year average?” Asking for two more baselines rather than one avoids a fight about which single year is fair, and the shape of the answer is the answer.

082

“Only nought point one percent of cases were affected.”

The Small Rate on a Big Number

WHY IT WORKS

The rate is chosen because it is small, when the count is the thing that matters. A tenth of a percent of forty million is forty thousand people, and the sentence is designed so that nobody performs that multiplication.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Perform it out loud. “That’s forty thousand people. How many is acceptable?” Converting the rate to a count takes four seconds and changes the emotional weight of the discussion, without disputing the figure at all.

083

“There’s no evidence of any harm.”

Absence of Evidence

WHY IT WORKS

It is technically true whenever nobody has looked, and it sounds like a finding of safety. The gap between *we found nothing* and *nobody has checked* is invisible in the phrasing.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Has anyone looked, and how hard?” A well-designed study that found nothing is reassuring and worth saying so. No study at all is not, and the same sentence covers both.

084

“I’ll let the data speak for itself.”

Pretending Numbers Are Not Interpreted

WHY IT WORKS

It presents a selection and a framing as though it were raw reality, and it positions any disagreement as an argument with arithmetic rather than with the person who chose what to show.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Data doesn’t speak. What did you leave out?” Not hostile, just accurate. Every chart is a set of decisions about inclusion, axis and comparison, and naming that returns the argument to the person who made them.

Weaponising Doubt

Doubt is the correct response to most claims, which is what makes it such good cover. Everything in this chapter is a virtue turned into a tool: scepticism, the demand for evidence, the awareness that experts have been wrong before, the recognition that correlation is not causation. Each of those is a genuine intellectual instrument. Each of them can be pointed at any claim whatsoever, indefinitely, without ever proposing anything.

That is the tell, and it is worth stating early because it is the only reliable one. Honest doubt is specific and it can be satisfied. It names what would change its mind. Weaponised doubt is general and permanent: whatever evidence arrives, there is a reason it does not count, and no evidence is ever described in advance that would settle the matter.

So the counter for the whole chapter is a single question, asked once and asked genuinely: **what would change your mind?** A serious sceptic has an answer, often a good one, and the conversation becomes worth having. Somebody using doubt as a shield will not answer it, and their refusal is more informative to everybody listening than any evidence you could produce.

Ask it without triumph. It is a real question, and about a third of the time you will get a real answer that improves your own position. The other two thirds it ends the move without a fight.

085

“The science on this isn’t settled.”

Manufactured Uncertainty

WHY IT WORKS

No science is ever fully settled, so the sentence is always true and always available. It converts a strong finding into an open question by describing the small remaining uncertainty as though it were the whole picture.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask about the shape of the disagreement. “What’s still open, and what’s agreed?” Real live controversies have a location. When the answer is that everything is open, that is not a description of the field, it is a description of the strategy.

086

“That study was funded by the industry, of course.”

The Funding Smear

WHY IT WORKS

Funding is a genuine source of bias, so the observation is legitimate and the inference is not. Noting who paid feels like doing due diligence while functioning as a complete substitute for reading the paper.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Grant it and go to the method. “That’s worth knowing. Does it change what they measured?” Bias operates through design and reporting, which are visible. If the funding did distort it, you can point at where. If you cannot, the objection has not yet done any work.

087

“Correlation isn’t causation.”

A True Sentence Used as a Stop Sign

WHY IT WORKS

It is correct and it sounds like the end of the discussion. Deployed as a full response rather than an opening one, it exempts the speaker from engaging with whatever the study did to address exactly that problem.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Agree and continue. “No, so what would you want to see? They controlled for income and did a five-year follow-up.” Causation is established by accumulation, not by a single result, and describing the accumulation is the answer this sentence pretends does not exist.

088

“You can prove anything with statistics.”

Blanket Discrediting

WHY IT WORKS

It discredits an entire category of evidence in six words, and it costs nothing, and it feels worldly. Once accepted, no number can be introduced by anybody, which reliably suits whoever has fewer of them.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“You can’t, actually. What’s wrong with these ones?” Said lightly. The general claim collapses the moment it has to become a specific criticism, and it turns out there is no specific criticism available.

089

“We need more research before we do anything.”

Perpetual Insufficiency

WHY IT WORKS

More research is always possible, so the condition can never be met, and the delay it produces looks like prudence rather than opposition. It also puts the burden of certainty entirely on one side.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask for the threshold. “How much would be enough, and by when?” A number and a date turn an indefinite delay into a plan. The absence of both is the answer, and it is a much clearer answer than any argument about the existing evidence.

090

“There are good people on both sides of this.”

False Balance

WHY IT WORKS

Even-handedness is a virtue and this borrows its appearance. Where the evidence is lopsided, presenting two

sides as equally weighted is itself a distortion, delivered in the voice of fairness.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Accept the civility and restore the weights. “Both sides deserve a hearing. They don’t have the same amount of evidence, and that’s worth saying too.” You have conceded nothing about tone while declining to concede the substance, which is the only version of this that does not sound partisan.

091

“They told us eggs were bad for us, and now they’re fine.”

The Past Reversal Gambit

WHY IT WORKS

It is true, it is memorable, and it generalises from a handful of famous reversals to everything. The implied conclusion is that current advice is as likely to flip as past advice, regardless of how well established it is.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Point at the strength rather than the fact of the finding. “Some things reversed. The ones that reversed were thin to begin with. How strong is this one?” That distinction is the whole answer, and it also happens to be a useful way to read health news.

092

“Show me one study that proves it definitively.”

The Impossible Standard

WHY IT WORKS

Proof is a word from mathematics and does not apply to empirical questions, so the demand can never be met. It sounds rigorous while asking for something that does not exist in any field.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Name the achievable standard. “Nothing outside maths gets proved. What we’ve got is nine studies, three designs, same direction. What would you accept?” Refusing the word without refusing the scrutiny is the move here.

093

“There are still a lot of unanswered questions.”

Unspecified Doubt

WHY IT WORKS

It gestures at problems without naming any, so there is nothing to answer and the impression of a shaky case lingers. It is also unfalsifiable: there are always unanswered questions.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Which ones? I’ll go and look.” The request is friendly and it is fatal. Either you get a list, which is useful and

answerable, or the questions turn out not to exist in any specific form.

094

“I’m just a sceptic by nature, that’s all.”

Scepticism as Identity

WHY IT WORKS

It converts a position into a personality, which puts it beyond argument. You cannot rebut somebody’s temperament, and framing doubt as a permanent trait excuses it from ever being satisfied by anything.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Take the identity seriously and test it. “So am I. What would convince you?” Real scepticism is a method with an exit; it can say what would change its mind. Identity scepticism has no exit, and the question makes the difference plain.

095

“Ask yourself who benefits from you believing that.”

The Motive Inversion

WHY IT WORKS

It replaces the question of whether a claim is true with the question of who gains, which is unanswerable and endless. It also flatters the listener as somebody who sees behind things.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Answer it and move past it. “Plenty of people, probably. It’s still either true or false, and here’s how we’d check.” Following the money is a legitimate investigative technique and a terrible epistemology, and the difference is whether it ever returns to the evidence.

096

“I’m not saying it’s wrong, I’m just raising the possibility.”

The Costless Suggestion

WHY IT WORKS

Raising a possibility puts it in the room while disclaiming responsibility for it. It requires no support, cannot be rebutted, and leaves a residue of doubt that outlasts any correction.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask what the possibility rests on. “Is there anything behind it, or is it just possible?” Everything is possible. The distinction between a possibility with evidence and a possibility without one is the entire question, and drawing it politely ends the move.

False Choices

Most decisions have more than two options, and almost every persuasive account of a decision presents exactly two. This is not usually dishonesty. It is compression, and compression is necessary, because nobody can hold nine possibilities in mind while being asked to choose. The abuse begins when the compression is done by somebody with a preference, and the option they dislike is the one that vanishes.

What makes the family hard to counter is that objecting sounds like refusing to decide. The person offering two options is being practical. The person saying there might be a third is being difficult, and they usually cannot describe the third one on the spot, because they have just been handed the framing thirty seconds ago.

That asymmetry is worth naming to yourself before you walk into a meeting where a decision is being framed. You will be at a disadvantage that has nothing to do with being wrong. It comes from the fact that the person who chose the options has been thinking about them for a week.

The counters below are about buying the time to find the missing option, and about declining to accept a choice as complete simply because it has been

presented as complete. The most useful sentence in the chapter is the least impressive one: those are two of the options.

097

“We either act now or we accept it will never happen.”

The False Dilemma

WHY IT WORKS

Two options presented as exhaustive, with the speaker’s preference made to look like the only responsible one. The audience evaluates which of the two is better rather than whether there are only two.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Those are two of the options.” Then pause. The sentence is unremarkable and it reopens the field, and the pause is what gives you and everybody else the moment needed to think of a third that nobody has mentioned.

098

“You’re either with us on this or you’re against us.”

The Loyalty Binary

WHY IT WORKS

It converts a question about a proposal into a question about allegiance, and allegiance is answered instantly and emotionally. Anybody with a specific reservation is sorted into the opposition before they can state it.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Refuse the sorting and be concrete. "I'm for the goal and against clause four, which I think will backfire." Specificity is the only escape. A general answer to a binary is a binary answer.

099

"Would you rather we did what the last lot did?"

The Worse Option Defence

WHY IT WORKS

A bad thing is measured against a worse thing and comes out looking like a success. The comparison is real and the standard is wrong, since the alternative on offer is not the only alternative that existed.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Move the comparison. "Better than the worst option available isn't the test. Compared with what we said we'd do, how did it go?" Choosing the benchmark is most of the argument, and asking for a different one is not a dodge.

100

"It's not perfect, but what's the alternative?"

Argument from No Alternative

WHY IT WORKS

It grants the criticism, which disarms you, and then makes the absence of a ready replacement into a positive

case. It is effective because it is often sincerely meant and sometimes correct.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Let’s find out. Nobody’s looked yet.” Then propose the search rather than the substitute. The claim that no alternative exists is a claim about the world, and it is nearly always made without anybody having checked.

101

“We’ve already put eighteen months into this.”

The Sunk Cost Appeal

WHY IT WORKS

The effort spent is real and it feels like an asset. It is not: the eighteen months are gone whatever you decide next, and they carry emotional weight precisely because abandoning them means admitting they were wasted.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Frame the decision forward. “If we were starting today, knowing what we know, would we choose this?” It is the same question stripped of the past, and it often produces a different answer from the same people in the same room.

102

“Fine, so what would you do instead?”

Demanding a Full Alternative

WHY IT WORKS

It makes the right to criticise conditional on having a finished plan, which almost nobody has. Pointing out that a bridge will fall down does not require you to be able to design a bridge.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Separate the two jobs. “I don’t have a plan and this one has a hole in it. Both things can be true.” Say it without apology. Once accepted, the criticism can be examined on its own, which is the only way it can be either fixed or dismissed properly.

103

“It’s a trade-off. You can’t have both.”

The Invented Trade-off

WHY IT WORKS

Real trade-offs exist everywhere, so an invented one is camouflaged among them. Presenting two goods as necessarily opposed forecloses the possibility that some arrangement gets more of each.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask for the mechanism. “What makes them exclusive?” Genuine trade-offs have a reason: a fixed budget, a physical constraint, a finite hour. Invented ones have only an assertion, and the question distinguishes them immediately.

104

“Look, something is better than nothing.”

Ignoring That Something Can Be Worse

WHY IT WORKS

It sounds like pragmatism and it feels generous towards action. It quietly assumes the floor is zero, when a badly designed intervention can leave things worse than leaving them alone.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Sometimes. What happens if this one doesn’t work?” Asking for the downside case is not obstruction; it is the missing half of the comparison, and a proposal that has not considered it is not finished.

105

“We have to start somewhere.”

The Unexamined First Step

WHY IT WORKS

It grants that the step is imperfect while making any objection sound like a demand for perfection. It also implies that the direction has been agreed, when the direction is the thing in dispute.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Agreed. Does this step get us closer, or does it just get us moving?” The distinction is the point. Motion and progress feel identical from inside a meeting and are different a year later.

106

“That’s just the price of doing business.”

Naturalising the Cost

WHY IT WORKS

It reclassifies a choice as a law of nature. Once a cost is described as inherent, arguing about it looks naive, and the fact that somebody decided to accept it disappears from the conversation.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Who set that price?” Costs presented as inevitable are usually the outcome of a decision that could be revisited, and often the decision was made years ago by people who are no longer here.

107

“There isn’t time to explore other options.”

Urgency as an Argument

WHY IT WORKS

Time pressure is the most reliable way to close a decision, because it converts thinking into delay. Sometimes it is genuine, which is what makes the manufactured version so hard to challenge.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Test the deadline. “What happens if we decide on Thursday instead of today?” A real deadline has consequences that can be named. A manufactured one has a mood, and the question separates them without accusing anybody.

108

“So you’d rather do nothing at all.”

The Inaction Smear

WHY IT WORKS

It assigns you the one position nobody wants to hold. Inaction is the default and the default is always available to be blamed, so the person defending scrutiny is made to own everything that happens while scrutiny takes place.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Name the third option out loud, even if it is small. “I’d rather do the pilot first, and then decide.” A concrete, modest alternative is the only reliable answer to this, because it makes the choice visibly wider than two.

IV

PLAYING THE ROOM

Emotional Leverage

Feeling is not the enemy of argument. A person who felt nothing about anything would have no reason to argue and no way to judge which conclusions mattered. Every move in this chapter takes something legitimate, sympathy, worry, loyalty, guilt, and uses it to close a question that has not been answered.

The distinguishing feature is direction. Emotion that is part of an argument points at the world: this policy will hurt these people, and here is how. Emotion used as leverage points at you: agreeing is how you demonstrate that you are not cruel, and disagreeing will cost you something socially. Notice which way it is aimed and most of the chapter becomes visible.

These are the hardest moves to counter, for a reason that has nothing to do with logic. Countering them well requires being briefly, visibly unmoved by somebody's distress, in front of people who are watching. That feels bad, and it looks bad, and sometimes the distress is entirely real, which means you can be right about the argument and still be the one who behaved badly.

So the counters here are gentler than elsewhere and slower. Nearly all of them separate two things that

have been deliberately fused: acknowledging the feeling, which costs nothing and is usually deserved, and answering the question, which is a different act. Do the first properly and unhurriedly, and the second becomes possible.

Where the distress is genuine and the stakes are personal, consider that winning may not be the thing to do. That is not in the counters below because it is not a counter. It is the alternative to using them.

109

“Think about what this will do to the children.”

The Appeal to Sympathy

WHY IT WORKS

It is vivid, immediate and usually true of somebody. A specific imagined child overwhelms an abstract argument about aggregate outcomes, because that is how human attention is built.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Take the child seriously and widen the frame. “That’s exactly who I’m thinking about, which is why I want to know what happens to the other four hundred.” You have accepted the emotional premise entirely, which removes the accusation of coldness, and reintroduced the arithmetic that was being crowded out.

110

"I'd be really hurt if you went ahead with that."

Pre-emptive Guilt

WHY IT WORKS

It attaches a personal cost to a decision before the decision is made, so any assessment of the merits now has a thumb on the scale. It is also honest, which makes it hard to name as a tactic.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Acknowledge it, then separate it. "I don't want to hurt you, and I want to decide this on what it does. Can we do the merits first, and then talk about you and me?" Both things get their turn, which is the only fair version.

111

"After everything I've done for you."

The Debt Claim

WHY IT WORKS

It converts a disagreement into an act of ingratitude. The debt is usually real, which is why it lands, and the implication is that the debt is payable in agreement.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Honour the debt and decline the currency. "You have, and I'm grateful, and I don't think I can repay it by agreeing with something I think is wrong." Said warmly, it is hard to argue with, because it concedes every fact and refuses only the inference.

112

“Could you live with that on your conscience?”

Responsibility Transfer

WHY IT WORKS

It makes you the author of an outcome you are merely declining to prevent, which is a much heavier position. It also skips the question of whether the proposed action would prevent it.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Put the causation back. “I could if it wouldn’t have helped. Would it?” That returns the discussion to whether the intervention works, which is where it belongs, and it does so without disclaiming responsibility in general.

113

“I’m only saying this because I’m worried about you.”

Concern as Control

WHY IT WORKS

Concern cannot be refused without appearing to reject care, and it licenses statements that would otherwise be unacceptable. It is also frequently sincere, which is what makes it so difficult.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Accept the concern, decline the conclusion. “I know you are, and I’ve thought about it, and I’m going to do it anyway.” No argument about whether the worry is legitim-

ate. That argument has no end, and it is not the one you need to win.

114

“Everyone’s been really upset about it, actually.”

The Reported Distress

WHY IT WORKS

It brings absent people into the room as evidence, and their feelings cannot be examined or contradicted. It also implies a consensus you were not present for and cannot check.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask for the substance behind the feeling. “That’s worth knowing. What is it they think went wrong?” Distress reported second hand is an invitation to guess. Converting it into a specific complaint is the only way to do anything useful with it.

115

“You’re the only one who can sort this out.”

Flattery as Obligation

WHY IT WORKS

It combines a compliment with a job. Declining now means both refusing the task and rejecting the flattering picture of yourself, and most people will take on more than they should rather than do that.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Keep the compliment, examine the job. "That's kind. Let's look at whether I should, separately from whether I can." Splitting capability from obligation is what makes it possible to say no without appearing to deny the compliment.

116

"I don't want to fight. I just want us to be all right."

Peace as a Weapon

WHY IT WORKS

It frames the continuation of the discussion as aggression. Whoever wants to keep talking about the problem is now the one disturbing the peace, and the unresolved thing is preserved by the very desire for calm.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Agree about the goal and name the route. "So do I, and I don't think we get there by leaving this. Ten minutes, then we stop." The time limit is what makes it acceptable. Open-ended is what people are refusing, more often than the subject itself.

117

"Fine. Do whatever you want."

The Withdrawal

WHY IT WORKS

It ends the exchange while transferring all responsibility to you, and it leaves the disagreement intact and un-

spoken. Nothing has been resolved, and pursuing it now means chasing somebody who has left.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Decline the transfer without pursuing. "I don't want to do whatever I want, I want us to agree. Come back to it when you're ready." Then genuinely leave it. Chasing a withdrawal confirms that it works.

118

"You know how this is going to make me look."

Reputational Hostage

WHY IT WORKS

It introduces a cost to somebody you care about, and the cost is social, which means it cannot be argued away with facts. The right answer to the question becomes secondary to the standing of a person in the room.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Take it seriously and put it in its place. "I don't want that either. Is there a way to do the right thing and manage how it looks?" Very often there is, and it goes unexplored because the two questions were presented as one.

119

“Imagine it was your own mother in that ward.”

Forced Identification

WHY IT WORKS

It replaces judgement with imagination, and imagination is partial by design. You are asked to reason from the position of maximum personal stake, which is the position from which policy is judged worst.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Accept the exercise and note its limits. “I’d want everything, immediately, and I’d be a terrible person to ask about the allocation.” That is honest, sympathetic, and makes the point that the strength of feeling is exactly why the decision is not made that way.

120

“I’m sorry you feel that way.”

The Apology That Is Not One

WHY IT WORKS

It has the shape of an apology and the content of a diagnosis. Nothing is admitted, the grievance is relocated into your feelings, and the speaker has been publicly gracious.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Name what an apology would be about. “I’m not after an apology for my feelings. I’d like to know whether you think the thing itself was wrong.” That is the question the

EMOTIONAL LEVERAGE

form was designed to skip, and asking it plainly is the only way to get it back.

Running Out the Clock

Some arguments are not won. They are outlasted. The point is never refuted, it is deferred, referred, widened, minuted and scheduled until the moment for acting on it has passed, and then it stops being relevant on its own. Nobody has to say no. The calendar says it for them.

This is the characteristic move of institutions rather than individuals, and it is worth a chapter because it is nearly invisible from inside. Every step is procedurally correct. Taking something offline is sensible. Getting the right people in the room is sensible. Checking with legal is sensible. It is only when you stand back and notice that eleven sensible steps have produced no decision in five months that the shape becomes clear.

The person doing it often does not experience themselves as doing anything. They are being careful, and being careful is indistinguishable from stalling except in one respect: stalling never has a date attached.

That is the whole counter, and it is the same for every entry below. **Attach a date and a name to everything.** Who is doing it, by when, and what happens if it does not happen. Say it out loud in the meeting and put it in the note afterwards. Do that consistently and most of this chapter becomes unusable

against you, without you ever having accused anybody of anything.

Write things down. It is unglamorous and it is the single most effective habit in this book.

121

“Let’s take this offline.”

The Offline Burial

WHY IT WORKS

It removes the item from the room where a decision could be witnessed and moves it somewhere with no minutes and no attendees. Perfectly reasonable for detail, and reliably fatal to anything raised inconveniently.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Happy to. You and me, Thursday morning?” Naming two people and a day converts the offline into an actual appointment. Without that, offline means nowhere.

122

“Let me come back to you on that.”

The Indefinite Deferral

WHY IT WORKS

It is a promise with no due date, which means it is not a promise. It also feels like progress in the moment, so nobody objects, and the absence of a deadline is only noticed weeks later.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“By when? I’ll put it in the note.” The second half is what matters. A deferral that appears in writing with a date

has to be either honoured or explicitly broken, and most people would rather honour it.

123

“We should get the right people in the room before we decide.”

Widening to Stall

WHY IT WORKS

It is unanswerable, because the right people should be in the room, and every additional person makes scheduling harder. Widening is the most respectable way to slow anything down.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Who’s missing, and can we get them this week?” Naming the gap makes it fillable. Left unnamed, the missing people multiply each time the question comes up.

124

“Could you put that in writing for me?”

Process as Friction

WHY IT WORKS

It converts a two-minute conversation into an hour of work, and it is legitimate, which is the beauty of it. Repeated a few times, it makes raising things expensive enough that people stop.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Do it, and make it short. Three sentences and a question, not a document. Then send it with a date on the reply.

The friction only works if you produce something long enough to be worth avoiding.

125

“Let’s park that for now.”

Parking Forever

WHY IT WORKS

It sounds like ordinary agenda management, and it is, until you notice that nothing ever comes out of the car park. There is no mechanism by which a parked item returns unless somebody builds one.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Parked until when?” Then write it in the list of parked items with the date. The list is the mechanism. Without it, parking is a euphemism for discarding.

126

“We’re nearly out of time, so let’s move on.”

Clock Management

WHY IT WORKS

The person controlling the agenda controls which items get the minutes, and the item that gets the last four minutes cannot be decided properly. Nothing needs to be refused; it simply does not fit.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Move it, don’t drop it. “Then let’s start with it next time.” Say it before the meeting closes, so it is in the record. An item that has been squeezed twice and named twice is much harder to squeeze a third time.

127

“Just to give a bit of background before I answer.”

The Preamble

WHY IT WORKS

It consumes the available minutes with material nobody can object to, and by the time the background is finished the question has lost its urgency, or the meeting has.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask for the order to be reversed. “Can I get the short answer first, and then the background?” Almost nobody refuses this, and it turns out the short answer is often thirty seconds long.

128

“I’d need to run that past legal.”

Borrowed Delay

WHY IT WORKS

It transfers the decision to somebody not present, who has their own queue, and it is impossible to argue against without appearing reckless. The delay is real and the responsibility for it has been outsourced.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Of course. Shall I send them the question today?” Offering to do the sending is what separates a real check from a shelf. It is helpful, it is hard to refuse, and it puts a clock on it.

129

“I think this needs a proper working group.”

Referral to Committee

WHY IT WORKS

It is the most respectable form of burial available. A working group takes weeks to form, months to report, and its report arrives after the decision has been made by events.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“Good. Who chairs it, who’s on it, and when does it report?” Three questions. A serious proposal answers them; a burial cannot, and asking makes that visible without any accusation.

130

“Sorry, remind me of the question again?”

Forced Repetition

WHY IT WORKS

Each repetition costs you time and credibility, since restating the same point three times makes you look fixated rather than persistent, while the person asking appears merely attentive.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Read it, do not re-explain it. “It’s the second line of the note I sent: were the figures signed off?” Reading from a document takes eight seconds and cannot be made to look obsessive.

131

“We’ve been through all this before.”

Claiming It Is Settled

WHY IT WORKS

It asserts that the discussion has already happened and reached a conclusion, which makes reopening it a waste of everybody’s time. Whether it actually concluded is not examined.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

“We discussed it. What did we decide?” If there is a decision, you have your answer and should accept it. If nobody can state it, then it was discussed and not settled, and that difference is the entire point.

132

“Sorry, I’m going to have to jump.”

The Hard Stop

WHY IT WORKS

It ends the conversation unilaterally at a moment of the speaker’s choosing, usually just after a difficult question, and it is unchallengeable because everybody has other meetings.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Get one line in before they go. “No problem. I’ll send the question by email so we can pick it up.” Said quickly, it survives the departure. The item leaves the room in writing rather than evaporating with the call.

When You Are the One Doing It

Everything so far has been written from one side of the table. That was a convenience, and it was also a lie, because the honest version of this subject is that you use these moves. Not the crude ones. The respectable ones: the zoom out when the detail was against you, the request for a source you had no intention of reading, the sarcastic restatement that got a laugh, the offline that you never followed up.

You will have recognised some of them while reading and felt the small hot flush of it. That reaction is the most useful thing this book produces, and it is worth more than any of the counters, because the counters only protect you from other people.

There is a reason it happens to everyone. Once you believe a thing, the mind stops looking for reasons and starts looking for arguments, and those are different activities that feel identical from the inside. Reasons are what you use to decide. Arguments are what you use to win. The moment the conclusion is fixed, every rhetorical move becomes available and none of them feels dishonest, because you are not trying to deceive anybody. You are trying to bring them to something you already know is true.

That is the condition this chapter is about, and it has no clean solution. What it has are symptoms, and the entries below are the ones worth learning to notice in yourself, in the middle of the argument, while there is still time to stop.

The last one is the point of the chapter, and possibly the point of the book.

133

“I’m just being honest.”

Honesty as Licence

WHY IT WORKS

It converts an unkindness into a virtue, and it does so sincerely. Being honest and being unkind are independent, and the phrase is almost always deployed for something that was true and did not need saying.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask yourself the second question. Would you have said it if it were kind rather than cutting? Honesty that only surfaces when it wounds is not a commitment to truth, it is a permission slip, and you can hear yourself reaching for it.

134

“They started it.”

The Retaliation Excuse

WHY IT WORKS

It feels like justice and it is a decision to lower your own standard. It is also structurally unavailable to check, since both sides remember starting second.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Notice that you now have their standard rather than yours. If the move was bad when it was done to you, it did not improve on the way back. The only person whose conduct you were ever going to control has just stopped controlling it.

135

“Well, it worked, didn’t it.”

Effectiveness as Justification

WHY IT WORKS

Winning is real and visible, and the cost is neither. It is true that the move succeeded, and irrelevant to whether the position it defended was correct.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask what you won. If you got agreement without changing anybody’s understanding, you have a compliance that will not survive the first time somebody checks. That is not a win with a long shelf life.

136

“I knew I was right, I just couldn’t explain why at the time.”

Conclusion First

WHY IT WORKS

Sometimes it is true; intuition runs ahead of articulation and is often correct. It is also the exact sensation of motivated reasoning, and the two are indistinguishable from inside.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Write the reason down afterwards, when nobody is watching. If it comes easily, the intuition was doing real work. If you find yourself constructing rather than recalling, you have learned something uncomfortable and useful about that particular certainty.

137

“I’d stopped listening about halfway through.”

Deciding Before They Finished

WHY IT WORKS

Attention is expensive and prediction is cheap, so the mind fills in the rest of somebody’s argument from the first few sentences and spends the remainder preparing a reply. It feels like efficiency.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Try summarising their position back to them before you answer it. If you cannot, you were not listening, you were queueing. This one habit removes about half of the straw men you would otherwise commit.

138

“There was no point explaining the real reason to them.”

Condescension as Kindness

WHY IT WORKS

It presents a decision to be less than honest as consideration for somebody’s limits, and it is occasionally correct.

Mostly it is a way of avoiding a reason you would rather not defend.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask whether you could say the real reason out loud to them. If the answer is that they would disagree, that is not a reason to withhold it. If the answer is that they would be right to, you have found the actual problem.

139

“I had them on the ropes, so I kept going.”

Not Stopping at Enough

WHY IT WORKS

Momentum is pleasurable, and there is no natural signal to stop once the point is made. Continuing past the point converts a persuaded person into a humiliated one, and humiliated people do not concede.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Watch for the moment they stop defending and start absorbing. That is the end. Anything after it is not argument, it is collection, and it costs you the agreement you had just earned.

140

“I never actually said it was false.”

Technically True

WHY IT WORKS

It preserves deniability by leaving the claim implied rather than stated, which means you can believe yourself

to have been accurate while knowing exactly what impression you left.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Ask what they walked away believing, and whether you intended that. Communication is measured at the receiver. A sentence that is defensible in a transcript and misleading in a room was chosen for that property.

141

“I was fairly sure, so I said it.”

Confidence Without Checking

WHY IT WORKS

Checking is slow and confidence is free, and in most conversations nobody verifies anything. You will be right often enough that the times you are not will not correct the habit.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Calibrate out loud. “I think it’s about forty percent, but I’d want to check.” It costs one clause and it makes you more credible rather than less, because the times you do state something flatly then mean something.

142

“I wanted them to feel it.”

Wanting to Win More Than to Be Right

WHY IT WORKS

There is genuine pleasure in landing a line, and it is a different appetite from wanting to be understood. It usually

appears when something else has made you feel small earlier in the day.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Notice the appetite and treat it as information about you rather than about them. It is a reliable sign that this argument has stopped being about the subject, and the best available move is to stop talking for a minute.

143

“I’m not going to apologise for caring about this.”

Refusing to Concede Anything

WHY IT WORKS

Caring is real and it makes any retreat feel like a betrayal of the thing you care about. So you defend every part of your position equally, including the weak parts, which is how a good case gets discredited by its worst component.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

Concede the weakest part first, deliberately, out loud. It is the single most persuasive thing available to anybody in an argument, and it costs you the part you could not defend anyway.

144

“You know what, you’re right. I hadn’t thought of that.”

Losing on Purpose

WHY IT WORKS

Nothing in this book is more effective and almost nobody uses it. Conceding immediately and without conditions ends the contest, and what is left is two people looking at the same problem, which was supposed to be the point.

WHAT TO SAY BACK

This is the exit, and it is the last thing in the book for a reason. You are allowed to lose. You are allowed to say you have changed your mind, in public, without a face-saving clause attached. And you are allowed to walk away from an argument you could win, with somebody who is never going to change their mind, about something that will not matter by Friday. Recognising the moves is useful. Not needing to win is better, and it is available at any point, including right now, in the argument you are already having.

A Note on Sources

Quotation is a messy business, and anyone who tells you otherwise has not looked closely.

Lines migrate. They get compressed by repetition, smoothed by retelling, and reattached to whoever sounds most impressive. A remark made in passing by a minor essayist in 1890 becomes, after a century of misquotation, something Winston Churchill said during the war. Nobody does this maliciously. It happens because a good line wants a good owner, and the internet has industrialised the process.

Four names in particular function as magnets for orphaned quotations: Mark Twain, Albert Einstein, Winston Churchill and the Buddha. If you encounter a neat, quotable line attributed to any of them, the base rate says treat it with suspicion. Twain and Churchill were genuinely witty, which is precisely why so much wit that isn't theirs has ended up under their names.

Some specific cases worth knowing:

- **"Be the change you wish to see in the world"** is a popular condensation of a longer passage by Gandhi rather than something he wrote in those words.

- **"The definition of insanity is doing the same thing over and over and expecting different results"** is not Einstein, and has no reliable source at all. It does not appear in this book.
- **"Well-behaved women rarely make history"** is Laurel Thatcher Ulrich, writing in 1976. Not Marilyn Monroe, not Eleanor Roosevelt.
- **"Comparison is the thief of joy"** is universally credited to Theodore Roosevelt and has never been traced to anything he actually wrote. It appears here marked as attributed, because the observation is good regardless of who made it.
- **"When you find yourself in a hole, stop digging"** is associated with Denis Healey, who popularised it as a political maxim, but versions of it are considerably older.

Where a line in this book is disputed, paraphrased or of uncertain origin, it is marked **"attributed to"** or **"after"**. Where it belongs to a tradition rather than a person, it is marked as a proverb and given its language or culture of origin where that is known. Proverbs have no author by definition, and the various national labels attached to them reflect where they were collected, not where they began. Many of the same lines appear in a dozen languages.

A word on why this matters, since it might seem pedantic in a book of practical advice. Attribution is a claim about evidence. When you say Marcus Aurelius wrote something, you are saying it survived nearly two thousand years because people found it worth copying by hand, which is a genuine filter. When a line is falsely attributed, that filter is being borrowed rather

than earned. The idea might still be excellent. It simply hasn't been tested the way the label implies.

If you use one of these somewhere it matters, a speech, an application, an obituary, anything published, search the exact wording along with the word "misattributed" before committing to it. It takes a minute. The alternative is a corrective email from a stranger who has been waiting years for the opportunity.

Finally, the translations. Quotations from Greek, Latin, Chinese and Persian appear here in the English renderings that have become standard, which are frequently not the most literal. Seneca in particular reads far more like an aphorist in English than he does in Latin, where the sentences are longer and the point takes its time. This is a book for use rather than scholarship, so the familiar versions have been kept.

Index of Moves

A

Alignment, Forced 55
Ally, The Anonymous 28
Alternative, Argument from
No 79
Alternative, Demanding a
Full 81
Answer, Talking Over the 11
Anything, Refusing to
Concede 111
Appeal, The Sunk Cost 80
Argue, The Refusal to 56
Argument, Disappointment
as 40
Argument, The Fashion 58
Argument, Urgency as an 83
Assignment, Category 40
Assignment, Complicity 52
Association, Guilt by
Historical 27
Authority, Common Sense
as 47
Axis, The Truncated 66

B

Balance, False 72
Base, The Percentage With
No 62
Baseline, The Chosen 66
Because, After Therefore 64
Binary, The Loyalty 78
Burden, Outsourcing the 46
Burial, The Offline 98

C

Calm-Down, The 39
Card, Experience as
Trump 45
Catch, The Hypocrisy 54
Challenge, The Credential 38
Checking, Confidence
Without 110
Claim, The Consensus 44
Claim, The Debt 89
Claim, The Debunk 48
Committee, Referral to 102

Concession, Upgrading

Your 18

Control, Concern as 90

Cost, Naturalising the 83

D

Defence, The Worse

Option 79

Deferral, The Indefinite 98

Delay, Borrowed 101

Demand, The

Unfalsifiable 57

Denominator, The Number

With No 62

Dilemma, The False 78

Discrediting, Blanket 71

Dismissal, Margin of Error as
a 65

Disqualification, Position

as 54

Distress, The Reported 91

Doubt, Unspecified 74

E

Edit, The Retroactive 21

Enough, Not Stopping at 109

Euphemism, The 18

Evidence, Absence of 67

Evidence, Character

Reference as 42

Excuse, The Retaliation 106

Exit, The Compliment 12

F

Filibuster, The

Definitional 21

Finished, Deciding Before

They 108

First, Conclusion 107

Flaw, Making Precision a

Character 22

Forever, Deferring 11

Forever, Parking 100

Friction, Process as 99

G

Gambit, The Past Reversal 73

Grab, The Endorsement 47

Guilt, Pre-emptive 89

H

Hostage, Reputational 93

I

Identification, Forced 94

Identity, Scepticism as 75

Ignorance, Assumed 41

Implication, The 57

In, Smuggling the

Conclusion 19

Insider, The Anecdotal 49

Insufficiency, Perpetual 72

Interpreted, Pretending

Numbers Are Not 68

Inversion, The Motive 75

Invocation, The Discipline 46

INDEX OF MOVES

Isn't, The Reductio That 25

It, Denying the Attack While
Making 41

J

Justification, Effectiveness
as 107

K

Kindness, Condescension
as 108

L

Licence, Honesty as 106

M

Machine, The Fog 13

Man, The Pre-emptive
Straw 30

Man, The Straw 24

Management, Clock 100

Merge, The False 10

Move, The Straw Man
Accusation as a 30

N

Number, The Small Rate on a
Big 67

O

Obligation, Flattery as 91

One, The Apology That Is
Not 94

Out, The Zoom 8

P

Pinned, Refusing to Be 20

Point, Policing the Word Not
the 19

Policing, Tone 36

Preamble, The 101

Puppet, The Hypothetical
Sock 26

Purpose, Losing on 112

Purpose, Losing the Thread
on 14

Q

Question, Substituting the 9

Questions, Just Asking 28

Quote, The Misattributed 45

R

Record, The Attendance 53

Refutation, Interest as 38

Refutation, Social Pressure
as 56

Repetition, Forced 102

Restatement, The
Sarcastic 29

Retreat, Definitional 16

Right, Wanting to Win More
Than to Be 110

S

Scotsman, No True 17

Settled, Claiming It Is 103

Shield, Complexity as a 12

THE ART OF BEING RIGHT

Shield, The Humble 50	Sympathy, The Appeal to 88
Shown, The Sample You Are Not 63	T
Sign, A True Sentence Used as a Stop 71	Test, The Sincerity 52
Size, Significance Mistaken for 65	Thing, Renaming the 17
Slope, The Slippery 27	Think, Telling You What You 26
Smear, The Funding 70	Trade-off, The Invented 81
Smear, The Inaction 84	Transfer, Responsibility 90
Sneer, The Motive 36	Trap, The Consistency 39
Source, The Credential of the 48	Truce, The Premature 13
Specific, Dismissing the 10	True, Technically 109
Spread, The Mean Hiding the 64	U
Stall, Widening to 99	Uncertainty, Manufactured 70
Standard, The Impossible 74	Upgrade, The Motive 25
Standing, Denying the Argument's 55	W
Step, The Unexamined First 82	Weapon, Peace as a 92
Stop, The Hard 103	Whataboutery 8
Study, The Unnamed 44	Withdrawal, The 92
Suggestion, The Costless 76	Worse, Ignoring That Something Can Be 82
Suits, Dismissing Definition When It 20	Wrapper, The Politeness 37



The Art of Being Right

Three hundred and fifteen entries across twenty-one chapters,
drawn from a hundred and fifty-one sources.

Set in EB Garamond, cut by Octavio Pardo
after the types of Claude Garamont and Robert Granjon.

